



Naturalistic motifs in cobalt blues and chrome greens surround Islamic calligraphy in these Iznik wall tiles, commissioned for the Topkapi Palace during the classical age of Turkish art.

The Ottoman heyday

The empire reached its peak under Emperor Suleiman the Magnificent. He forged an alliance with the French against the Hapsburg rulers of the Holy Roman Empire, and signed a treaty with the Safavid rulers of Persia that divided Armenia and Georgia between the two powers and put most of Iraq into Ottoman hands. Suleiman conquered much of Hungary, and even laid siege to Vienna, although he did not succeed in taking it.

The Ottomans took their Islamic faith to their territories, building mosques everywhere—and with the mosques came scholarship and education. Ottoman cities were impressive. Constantinople itself was virtually rebuilt: the Ottomans reinforced its fortifications as well as adding many mosques, bazaars, and water fountains. The city's dazzling centerpiece was the royal palace of Topkapi, commissioned by Sultan Mehmed II in around the 1460s. Masons, stonecutters, and carpenters were summoned from far and wide to ensure the complex would be an enduring monument. It contained mosques, a hospital, bakeries, and a mint among much else, and attached to it were imperial societies of artists and craftsmen who produced some of the finest work in the empire.

Internal divisions **weaken the Byzantine Empire** from within.

The Ottomans attack and capture Constantinople.

Ottoman armies **conquer and pacify** large parts of eastern Europe and the Middle East.

The Ottomans govern conquered lands by **respecting local customs** and **allowing limited self-rule**.

The large, pluralist Ottoman Empire **spreads Islam** but fails to create a **single united culture**.

Gradual decline

This cultural flowering continued after Suleiman's death, but the empire faced serious challenges in other arenas. A rising population was putting pressure on available land; there were military threats and internal revolts; and defeat by a coalition of Catholic forces at the sea battle of Lepanto in 1571 prevented the empire's expansion further along the European side of the Mediterranean.

The Ottoman empire steadily lost prestige and influence until its decline earned it the title "the sick man of Europe." Incapable of responding to the convulsions of the 19th century, it lost territory and struggled against a rising tide of nationalism among its conquered peoples. Its long history finally ended with defeat in World War I and the foundation of the modern Turkish state by Kemal Atatürk. ■